themselves into unions to resist exploitation. It also supported the peasant community in their agitation against upper-caste landowners, who had historically denied them fair treatment. These experiences eventually led EMS and several other members of the CSP to join the Communist Party of India (CPI) in the late 1930s.

A global first

An incisive thinker and writer, EMS wrote extensively on how communism could be adapted to address Indian caste and class inequalities. In 1957, he led the CPI to victory in the Kerala assembly elections and became the state's first chief minister. The government he formed was one of the world's first democratically elected communist governments, and thus attracted global attention. One of the reasons the election of the CPI to power in 1957 was so remarkable is because, in the years preceding these polls, the communists had been unwilling to participate in parliamentary democracy. Many credit EMS with changing this and proving that the communists could come to power in a peaceful manner. Between 1957 and 1959, the government initiated several measures to address historical wrongs, including land reform, raising the minimum wage and protections against dismissal and eviction for poor workers and peasants. However, widespread agitation against new education policies led to the government being dismissed in 1959.

Communism is a political ideology whose aim is the overthrow of capitalism and the creation of a world where people can live and work as equals. It is based on the writings of Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, which were especially influential in the twentieth century.